Rick Bordelon - March 28, 2024

Creation & Flood

An exploration of the stories of Israel's neighbors

Abstract

The Bible is a subversive and counter-cultural book that invites us to participate in a story that expands beyond itself.

- The following will explore three ancient, extra-biblical creation and flood narratives of Israel's neighbors.
- The goal is to compare and contrast these accounts with their Biblical counterparts to (hopefully) gain a more enriched view of these first chapters of Genesis.
- **This outline is NOT about evolution.**
- The truth or falsity of evolution has no bearing on the proceeding topics.
  - Curious readers should explore, *Why Evolution Is True* by Jerry Coyne.
- Comments on evolution have no place in this conversation (this includes the presenter).
- Readers might find it uncomfortable to consider alternative versions of these stories. To ease trepidation when exploring this topic, remember the following:
  - All truth is God's truth - If you seek the truth, you will find God.
  - God is big enough to handle your questions.
  - God likes the Bible just the way it is - if He did not, it would look different.
- Peter Enns - The Bible Tells Me So pg. 9

> And what if *God* is actually fine with the Bible just as it is without needing anyone to stand guard over it? Not the well-behaved-everything-is-in-order version we create, but the messy, troubling, weird, and ancient Bible that we actually have?
>
> Maybe *this* Bible has something to show us about our own sacred journey of faith, and maybe God wants us to wander off the beach blanket to discover what that is.

- Approach this subject with an open mind.

Enuma Elish

The Babylonian Creation Epic



Marduk (image source: Wikipedia)

- Found on tablets in the ruins of Nineveh that date to the 7th century BC. Although it is likely that these tablets represent a tradition that extends much further (Stephany 1).
- This is around the same time the creation accounts of Genesis 1 & 2 were being written down (Stephany 5) although Enuma Elish's narrative is considered older (Enns 67).
- The main character of Enuma Elish is Marduk who became a major player in the Babylonian pantheon around 1800 BC (Enns 64).

Enuma Elish Synopsis

- Tiamut (the mother goddess) has baby gods.
- The birth of the gods corresponds to the creation of the universe (while not in the same order as Genesis).
- The baby gods start making lots of noise that bothers Tiamut.
- Tiamut and a god named Kingu plot to destroy the gods.
- The gods elect Marduk the Champion (Enuma Elish Tablet II pg.16) to defend them.
- The gods crown and throne Marduk (Enuma Elish Tablet IV pg. 24 - 26).
- Marduk battles and defeats Tiamut. It is a bloody battle and from her body, Marduk creates the earth.



Sun god battling Tiamut (image source: Wikipedia)

- Enuma Elish Tablet V pg. 32 - 33

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Marduk collected together all of the dribble that had spilled,
He collected it into clusters and made the scurrying clouds,
Giving rise to the winds and making it a source for the rains,
By gathering together her venom, he caused mists to swell
These he managed himself, to be controlled by his own hand
He set her head out and heaped up deep mounds of terrain
Severing open bursting springs, from which streams poured
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He made the Tigris and Euphrates rivers pour from her eyes
Sealed up her nostrils, so that the baleful river would not flow
He gathered together from her udder the treeless mountains
And drilled out holes so as to drain away the stagnant waters
Spanned her tail across, fixing it fast to tie up the heavens
And established the waters of the Apsu underneath his feet
Then he placed her thigh so as to bolster up the sky's vault
Half of her body was used to make the sky, half the earth
He twirled the creation, so that the insides of Tiamut spun
He spread out his net so that it spanned the entire world
Then fixed its end points to places upon heaven and earth
Binding them with knots after looping them around pillars
Then after he had set forth religion, designating its rituals,
He then tossed down the reigns, which were taken up by Ea

- After a successful battle, Marduk decides to create humanity.
- Enuma Elish Tablet VI pg. 38

Directing his words to Ea, of the plan he was mulling over,
My thought is to collect blood, and construct bones also,
My thought is to create a primitive human, to be called Man
So thus I am well inclined to give rise to primal humanity
and the work which is now done by the gods, he will do,
So that the gods will not be required to labor for evermore

- Marduk charges the god Ea to bring the treacherous Kingu to be slaughtered. Through his blood, humanity will be made.
- Enuma Elish Tablet VI pg. 39

"The one you seek is Kingu, it is he who provoked this war,
It was he who encouraged Tiamut to gather a battle force!"
And thus they chained him and brought him before Ea,
And they judged and sentenced him, and spilled his blood
From this Ea made humankind, from out of his lost blood
To him they gave the labor of the gods, thus freeing them

- From there, humanity worships and provides offerings to the gods; easing the gods' burden.

Enuma Elish Discussion

- There is no divine conflict in the Genesis accounts of creation; Yahweh is in complete control (Enns 66).
- In Enuma Elish, humanity is created to serve the gods. The gods are lazy, chaotic, and violent.
- In Genesis, Yahweh calmly creates the universe, the earth, and humanity without spilling a single drop of blood.
- **Other than simply relaying facts, why might ancient peoples want to depict their God (gods) this way? Why might we want to do the same?**
- Yahweh creates humanity *in his image* (Genesis 1:27). This is in stark contrast to Marduk who creates humanity by spilling the blood of his enemy. There is also no mention of humanity being made "in the image" of any of the gods in Enuma Elish.
- **How does being created in the image of God change the way we approach and interact with God? The world?**
- The creation accounts of Genesis 1 & 2 present a powerfully subversive image of its God compared to that of Enuma Elish.

Atrahasis

The Babylonian Flood Story



Cuneiform tablet with the Atrahasis epic
(image source: Wikipedia)

- Dated to around 1700 BC (Enns 74).
- The main character is Atrahasis. While this story is primarily a flood story, it also contains a creation account.

Atrahasis Synopsis

- In the pantheon of gods, there are lesser gods called Igigi. These are laborers. Tiring of their plight, the Igigi ask for their burden to be lifted.
- Atrahasis Tablet I pg.67

> Then Nintu will combine the clay with his flesh and blood
>
> So that a being, divine and mortal, will come from the clay
>
> Then we will hear the heart-beat rhythms from henceforth
>
> Let the spirit arise into being from out of the divine flesh,
>
> but let her relate to man, while he is alive, of his condition
>
> So they will never forget that the spirit is eternally made

- The mother goddess Nintu creates humans out of clay and imbues them with a divine spirit.
- Genesis 2: 7 -8

> Then the Lord God formed man from the dust of the ground and breathed into his nostrils the breath of life; and the man became a living being. And the Lord God planted a garden in Eden, in the east; and there he put the man whom he had formed.

- Atrahasis Tablet I pg. 70

> The man and wife will then live together, bound to one another
>
> And shall carry out the work for their existence, acting in virtue
>
> Never straying from the honorable, bringing the gifts of gods,
>
> To live according to the ways established for them by the gods

- Genesis 2: 23 - 24

> Then the man said, "This at last is bone of my bones and flesh of my flesh; this one shall be called Woman, for out of Man this one was taken." Therefore a man leaves his father and his mother and clings to his wife, and they become one flesh.

- The story continues to explore humanity's overpopulation.
- As in Enuma Elish, the gods grow annoyed with the ruckus caused by the humans.
- In order to stifle humans, the gods inflict several brutal plagues.
- BONUS READING: Atrahasis Tablet II pg. 82 & Genesis 3: 16-18

> Constrict the birth channel so as to deny a prosperous birth!
> Thus they made it so the humans would be denied their food

> To the woman he said, "I will greatly increase your pangs in childbearing; in pain you shall bring forth children, yet your desire shall be for your husband, and he shall rule over you." And to the man he said, "Because you have listened to the voice of your wife, and have eaten of the tree about which I commanded you, 'You shall not eat of it,' cursed is the ground because of you; in toil you shall eat of it all the days of your life;

- The final plague as decided by the gods was a flood.
- Atrahasis' house god, Enki, sends messengers to warn Atrahasis of his impending doom and instructs him to build a boat in order to survive.
- Atrahasis builds the boat and loads it with animals described as "Pure ones and impure ones, tall ones and short ones. Fat ones and skinny ones, and large ones and small ones" (Atrahasis Tablet III pg. 98).
- Atrahasis Tablet III pg. 102

> The boat settled itself upon the mountain of Nimush
> It took hold of the craft and would not let it wander
> for the first and second day, for the third and fourth day
> For the fifth and sixth day, the boat did not move an inch
> Then upon the seventh day Atrahasis released a dove -
> it flew out and came back, finding no place to perch,
> Then he reached his hand forth and released a swallow -
> The swallow flew here and there, then came back home
> For there was no promising place it might alight upon
> Then he reached his hand forth and released a raven -

> The raven flew, and seeing that the waters were receding
>
> It settled to eat, preen, fluff itself, and did not return

- Genesis 8: 4 - 12

> and in the seventh month, on the seventeenth day of the month, the ark came to rest on the mountains of Ararat. The waters continued to abate until the tenth month; in the tenth month, on the first day of the month, the tops of the mountains appeared. At the end of the forty days Noah opened the window of the ark that he had made and sent out the raven; and it went to and fro until the waters were dried up from the earth. Then he sent out the dove from him, to see if the waters had subsided from the face of the ground; but the dove found no place to set its foot, and it returned to him to the ark, for the waters were still on the face of the whole earth. So he put out his hand and took it and brought it into the ark with him. He waited another seven days and again he sent out the dove from the ark; and the dove came back to him in the evening, and there in its beak was a freshly plucked olive leaf; so Noah knew that the waters had subsided from the earth. Then he waited another seven days, and sent out the dove; and it did not return to him any more.

- Finally, the waters subside and the goddess Nintu wears a necklace of Lapis Lazuli to signify that she will not let a flood befall humanity again (Atrahasis Tablet III pg 103; cf. Genesis 9: 12 - 13).

Atrahasis Discussion

- Once again we see the Babylonian gods as lazy and anger prone. The God of Israel is more capable and personable.
- Humans are not Yahweh's slaves.
- Peter Enns - The Evolution of Adam pg. 78

> As horrific as the biblical flood story is, it makes a distinct point about Israel's God and the status of humanity vis-à-vis *Atrahasis.* Israel's God does not need to sleep, nor use humans as slaves. Humans are God's image-bearers, not a class of slaves created so the gods can be in repose.

- Genesis 6: 5 - 6

> The Lord saw that the wickedness of humankind was great in the earth, and that every inclination of the thoughts of their hearts was only evil continually. And the Lord was sorry that he had made humankind on the earth, and it grieved him to his heart.

- **What is the significance of the differences in motivation for destroying humanity between the Biblical account and Atrahasis?**

The Epic of Gilgamesh



The Deluge tablet of the *Gilgamesh* epic
(image source: Wikipedia)

- Found on tablets written in cuneiform in the ruins of the city of Nineveh (Sandars 9). These tablets are dated around the 7th century (Sandars 13) but its contents is thought to be the oldest of the three (Enuma Elish, Atrahasis, and Genesis), dating to around the second millennium (Sandars 8).

Gilgamesh Synopsis (the pertinent bits)

- Gilgamesh mourns the death of his friend Enkidu and seeks eternal life.
- Gilgamesh seeks out Utnapishtim, the only mortal to be granted eternal life. Utnapishtim survived a great flood and was granted eternal life by the gods.
- Upon finding Utnapishtim, the story of the great flood is recounted.
- Gilgamesh 5 pg. 108

> In those days the world teemed, the people multiplied, the world bellowed like a wild bull, and the great god was aroused by the clamor. Enlil heard the clamor and he said to the gods in council, "The uproar of mankind is intolerable and sleep is no longer possible by reason of the babel." So the gods agreed to exterminate mankind. Enlil did this, but Ea because of his oath warned me in a dream. He whispered their words to my house of reeds, "Reed-house, reed-house! Wall, O wall, hearken reed-house, wall reflect; O man of Shurrupak, son of Ubara-Tutu; tear down your house and build a boat, abandon possessions and look for life, despise worldly goods and save your soul alive. Tear down your house, I say, and build a boat. These are the measurements of the barque as you shall build her: let her beam equal her length, let her deck be roofed like the vault that covers the abyss; then take up into the boat the seed of all living creatures."

- Utnapishtim loads, "all that [he] had of gold and of living things, [his] family, [his] kin, the beast of the field both wild and time, and all the craftsmen." (Gilgamesh 5 pg. 109).
- "Even the gods were terrified of the flood, they fled to the highest heaven" (Gilgamesh 5 pg. 110).
- The boat comes to rest on a mountain (Gilgamesh 5 pg. 111; cf. Genesis 8:4).

- Gilgamesh 5 pg. 111

> When the seventh day dawned I loosed a dove and let her go. She flew away, but finding no resting-place she returned. Then I loosed a swallow, and she flew away but finding no resting-place she returned. I loosed a raven, she saw that the waters had retreated, she ate, she flew around, she cawed, and she did not come back. Then I threw everything open to the four winds, I made a sacrifice and poured out a libation on the mountain top.

- When the waters subside, a sacrifice is made and Ishtar declares, "… by the lapis lazuli round my neck I shall remember these days as I remember the jewels of my throat; these last days I shall not forget" (Gilgamesh 5 pg. 112).

Gilgamesh Discussion

- In the extra-Biblical accounts of the flood explored above, the gods bearing witness to the flood are afraid (Atrahasis Tablet III pg. 100 & Gilgamesh 5 pg. 110). The God of the Bible shares no such fear.
- **In light of Atrahasis and the Epic of Gilgamesh, how is Yahweh different from the other gods? Why are these differences important and/or significant?**

Conclusion

- Genesis connects Yahweh to humanity in a wholly unique and intimate way. Yahweh is a personal God. We are his image bearers. He created us not to labor and sacrifice for him, but to be in relationship with him.
- Whether or not Genesis is history or myth, it is an unquestionably powerful story of the God of Israel showing the gods of Babylon how it is done.
- Rachel Held Evans - Inspired pg. 9

> Contrary to what many of us are told, Israel's origin stories weren't designed to answer scientific, twenty-first-century questions about the beginning of the universe or the biological evolution of human beings, but rather were meant to answer then-pressing, ancient questions about the nature of God and God's relationship to creation.

- **Compared to each contemporary story explored above, the Bible presents a progressive and counter-cultural view of humanity in relation to God.**
- Ancient peoples that read the Biblical creation and flood narratives would have immediately recognized the elevated relationship between humanity and God.
- Being made in the image of God assigns dignity and intrinsic value to humanity; we are not subjects to the temperamental whims of a chaotic pantheon, we are the children of a loving God. All of us.

Sources

Not in MLA because ain't nobody got time for that

1. *Enuma Elish & Atrahasis* w/ introduction by Timothy J. Stephany
2. *The Epic of Gilgamesh* w/ introduction by N. K. Sandars
3. *The Evolution of Adam* by Peter Enns
4. *The Bible Tells Me So* by Peter Enns
5. *Inspired* by Rachel Held Evans